

Sting Like a Butterfly

Move over sex and shopping. It's time for Prada to meet Prado as glamorous girly fiction evolves into Chanel-clad satire.



THE DIARY OF A SOCIAL BUTTERFLY
by MONI MOHSIN
Random House India
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■ By Kaveree Bamzai

What is the most remarkable thing about Moni Mohsin's Prada-meets-Prado heroine? That Auntie Butterfly has never met a sentence in English she couldn't mangle into Urdu? Or that there isn't a designer six-inch heel she couldn't conquer? I suspect both. Don't be fooled by the rani-pink cover and the curly-wurly title. This is one social butterfly who has a sting in her Pucci-painted wings. An inhabitant of the subcontinent's Richistan who travels to Harrods (not London, mind you) every summer and treats an anti-Iraq war *juloos* like a fashion occasion in her new Nike shoes, Butterfly nevertheless manages to rustle up a fascinating record of Pakistan's turbulent times, from 9/11 to Benazir Bhutto's assassination.

What does she do right? Oh, almost everything. She may have exaggerated the Bollywood-obsessed, shopping-crazed, party-mad socialite but there is more than an element of truth in everything she writes. Growing out of her column for *The Friday*

Times, Mohsin, an impossibly well-connected Pakistani novelist who lives between London and Lahore, manages to say everything while uttering sweet nothings. Peace, she declares, is good for Pakistan since it will allow her *KBC*- and *Kyunki*-watching self to buy expensive jamewar shawls and pick up cheap servants who will do salaams for Rs 500 tips. America, she insists, is not a place for her because who would want to live in a "condom" in Los Angeles if you have to do your own laundry and even "*bharao* your petrol yourself?" As for the English, who do they think they are, not giving her a visa when she has to

stock up on her La Perla bras that have become *dheela* and her Dr Seebag cream (as in Dr Sebagh) that is finished?

All this, of course, while Nawaz Sharif is getting a hair transplant, Jemima is giving up on Imran Khan and frolicking in a *nanga* bikini with Who Grant and her Auntie Pussy is turning out to be a sleeve *ka* snake (as in *aasteen ka saanp*). This is a dark world Mohsin makes light with biting wit. Guards stand duty outside her home with Kalashnikovs, Americans fool around while Mullah Omar flees Kabul, "that also on a scooter", and thieves not only rob her neighbours but also give them a lecture on Islam-appropriate clothing. So even as Butterfly and her gal pals trust no one but their plastic surgeons, darzis, and waxing-*walis*, their husbands write long letters to Mush and Bush, while beardo-weirdos spread terror.

Yes, sometimes the humour is of the nudge-nudge, wink-wink variety but then subtlety is not very big in the subcontinent. Instead consumerism is, from the latest Samsonite suitcases to the Dior "*ka*" saddlebag. As is intellectualism, especially if it is imported, either in the form of Arundhati Roy, who Butterfly decides really needs to streak her hair, or Tariq Ali, who she is told is talking for the first time in Lahore since 1969 (so what was he doing till now, she asks, whispering?) The cover blurb tells us Butterfly is Pakistan's Bridget Jones. Dead wrong. She is Pakistan's Maureen Dowd, Jimmy Choos and a jaundiced view of life too. Yes indeed. Butterfly will go to God even if her husband goes to Lenin. ■



TRUTHFUL EXAGGERATION:
Mohsin

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